

2006: Delivering On Dreams



Maulik Jasubhai Publisher

LAST MONTH, Nicholas Negroponte of the MIT Media Lab, with Kofi Annan, unveiled a prototype of the much-awaited \$100 laptop. In an interview, Ajay Chowdhry of HCL discussed his plans to develop a PC that can be powered by pedalling—meaning you'd no longer need to worry about regular electric supply.

In the past twelve months, we have also seen new stories about the Simputer—an extremely economical handheld computer—and the e-Choupal initiative, which places Internet-enabled computers in rural areas. E-Choupal is used by farmers to get better weather forecasts and better prices for their grains. Then there's Intel's "community PC" initiative, as well as their WiMax initiative in Uttaranchal. Think about Project Shiksha, for that matter, which aims at making the masses IT-literate. What happens when you have an entire new generation that is tech-savvy?

These sound like interesting stories, and they pique common urban curiosity. However, one can't dismiss such news as merely interesting. These events are the rumblings of something seismic waiting to happen. Forget about

Bangalore. Forget about info parks. For the urbanites amongst us, it's easy to forget that the real India lives in the villages. The implications of these new developments are immense. Imagine what happens when rural computer education is recognised for what it is: a billion-dollar industry. Imagine what happens when WiMax and pedal-powered laptops bring the Internet to villagers who don't even have access to power. Imagine when suddenly, we as a country have a chance—and it is, admittedly, just a chance—to bridge the digital divide.

On the other side of the planet, we are witnessing profound changes that go beyond Moore's law. Google indexing libraries. 64-bit personal computing taking off. VoIP phones everywhere. HDTV livening up the home. The arrival of Internet TV. Nanotechnology creating products you and I can use. High-density optical discs coming to store shelves. Intensely immersive multi-player gaming, incredibly powerful and versatile personal assistants, truly digital workplaces! It all seems to be happening now!

My personal favourite is the possibility that newer games with increased complexity and the ability to create truly immersive experiences will make us more intelligent. One theory goes that games such as SimCity and Grand Theft Auto actually teach us new skills, without us realising that we are learning them. They teach us to make simultaneous decisions which are obvious to the situation as well focus on the macro issues of the overall objective. Surely these are skills that are not the exclusive domain of simulated environs.

On both sides of the planet, 2006 could well be the tipping point in mass rollout of tech.

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